Chapter 4

The Elephant First Found Water

SUMMARY. The elephant was the one who first found water. He hid it from people and drank it alone. But the mud from the water stuck to his ankles and his wife, the Beautiful Aardvark Girl, asked the others how he could have found water and could be drinking it without sharing. Her husband pretended it was plain sand they were seeing on his ankles. The Aardvark Girl's brothers tracked him and saw him drinking water. When he went off eating trees, they drank up all the water and then filled the waterhole with their piss. When the elephant came back he thought it was plain water and went to drink. But the piss refused. As he turned away, he saw the brothers, who had spent the day making spears, sitting with their sister in their midst. The elephant tried to grab his wife with his trunk, but the brothers stabbed him so that spears met this way and that inside his body and he died. The brothers were little birds, the swallows that come with the rain.

SPEAKER. *|Asa N!aan*

RECORDED. Kauri, Botswana, 1971

TRANSCRIBED BY. *|Ai!ae Fridrick |Kunta, Hacky Kgami Gcao*

ee, haa, aia, ha !xo m kxaice ho ka g!u
yes, he, my mother, the elephant first found water
ee
2 *yes*
ha !xo hin tsi kxaina ho ka g!u
the elephant was the one who first found water

o n|e'e te ku tchi ka
he drank it alone
ee
yes
te kaahn ju ko ka te o n|e'e te tchi ka te
and hid it from people and drank it alone and
ka g‡kaa hin
that mud
ka g‡kaa ku ǁae ha !'homsi
the mud stuck to his ankles
ka ha u cu
then he went and lay down
ka ha G!kunǁ'homdima ko "ju hoo,
then Beautiful Aardvark Girl said, "people,
ju hee, hatce !'hoan he kuri ka, ha re o jua ho g!u he te ku tchi te |oa !oa e?"
people, what is it that this man now, is he a person who found water and is drinking without telling us?"
ka ha !'hoan !xau
and her husband refused
ka ko "mi m |oa tchi g!u
and he said "I'm not drinking water
te kxa |'hoan si hin to'a te a se"
and it is plain sand which you see"
aia, ha koe nǁae
mother, that was what he said
ka
and
g‡ahan te !oa ha !o-sin te ko "ju hoo,
earlier she had told her brothers and said "people,
!'hoan he o mi ma o ha khoeca ho g!u he kaahn,
my husband perhaps found water and kept it secret from us,
ku kxuan m.
is being stingy to us.
n|ang i kxoe, m gǁa ha !uh, n|ang
come now, let us follow his spoor, and
g|ae kxoa tca ha ku tchia koa ke"
go to look for what he is drinking here"
a'u tsa'a mi?
do you understand me ?
te aie
and mother

si tuih te g‖a ha !uh te ǀoo ha te gǀae se te ha ǂaeh tchi ka
they stood up and followed his spoor and tracked him and went and saw him and he arrived and was drinking it
te to'a te !'hu u
and went off gathering
khama jua ku 'm !aihnsi nǀa
because he is a person who obviously eats trees
ee aia
yes, mother
ha gǀae cu te ku 'm ka !aihnsi te si tsi ǂaeh ‖kae te tchi !hun ka
he spent a long time eating trees and they came together and drank it all up
te si gǀxam waqnsi
and all their urine
si gǀxam g!a'in ‖'a g!u n!ang
they urinated the waterhole full
te ha 'm, 'm ka g!anisi te haa ǀam ku ca'an koa ke
and he ate, ate the roots and the sun was going down
ha koh ha ni te, ha ku tsi te se cu ka te khoeca ko g!u ǀ'hoan
he tried, he came and saw it lying there and thought maybe it was plain water
te tsi ǂaeh te
and came and
ǂ'aia ka ko ‖'a ha xuxua kahinto'a, ha ǂ'ai te
dipped it up with that trunk of his, he dipped it up and
ko ha tchi te ka koh (clap!) ka !xau
wanted to drink it but (clap!) it refused
te ha n‖haa koh ha n!abi hin te se nǀang si tzi
and just as he was turning around he saw the group of them sitting there
a tsa'a, aie?
you understand, mother?
ha se si tzi, se nǀang si te si ca'an koa ke te
he saw their group, saw them sitting and there were many of them
g‖aan te ku ku'ua !u!usi
(they) had spent the day heating and hammering spearpoints
mi ǂxae
my daughter
gǀae ku se nǀanga haa dshau ko ha !osin !ka te
went and saw his wife sitting in the midst of her brothers
g!xa ha buxu te koh ha ni ku gu ha dshau
took out his trunk and tried to grab his wife
ha !osin nǂhaoh te ‖kaea ‖'akoa
her brothers walked and gathered together there
mi ǂxae
my daughter

mi ǂxae hee
my daughter here
mi ǂxae hee
my daughter here
ha !osin nǂhaoh te ǁkaea ǁ'akoa te si ko "ee,
her brothers walked and gathered there and they said "yes,
a n|a o dshau
you are of course a woman
te nǁaqe gǂhanha ku koh a
and men long ago did bad things to you
te ǁa'ike e!a !hun ha !xo hin ke"
so today we are going to kill this elephant"
ha !osin
her brothers
koe nǁae te
thus said and
!u!usi m ǂhoǂhoa khoe, !u!usi m ǂhoǂhoa khoe, !u!usi ka a ku se ka
spears met this way and that inside his body, if you were there watching
ǁ'a tzama mhi sa hi hin he o g!a hiasi
then these little birds of the rain
ee
yes
ǁ'a hi sa ku ihin, ka ku ihin
those that swerve this way and that way
okaa ka hin tsi si koh ku !'ang ha !xo
that's how they stabbed the elephant
te ka, ǁ'a ka hin ke te hi, |aake n!anga ke hi |oa ihin
and that's how those birds today swerve this way and that
mi ǂxae
my daughter
te si gani ǁ'a !xo n!a'an ha hin tsi to'a
and they rolled over that big elephant there
ee, aie
yes, mother
te goaq ha ka,
and long ago he,
ha ka !ai te
he died and
si ko "ee, e!a m !hun a"
they said "yes, we have killed you"
ka ju ka
and so people have

ǁ’a kahin ke te ju ǀaa ka ku gu passa ka gǀae ku !hun ha !xo
so today people get a permit and go and kill an elephant
ee, aie
yes, mother
khuin ǀ’ae ha !xo o n‡haoha te ha hin tsi kxaice ho g!u
that”s how the elephant walked and he was the one who first found water
ee, aia
yes, mother
te g!a ka ku cua ha hin tsi nǁae te g!a ka ku cua,
and rain has fallen, this one caused the rain to fall
ka g!a
the rain
ha hin tsi ka ko g!a ka ku cua nǀang ju ku tchi g!u
this one said that rain should fall so people could drink water
ee, aia
yes, mother
te o ha !xo hin tsi
and it was the elephant here
mi ‡xae
my daughter